What about the MMR region, given the fact that even new development areas like Kharghar are already saturated? Also given the urban: rural population demography ratio of 60:40 per cent.

SVRS: Very good point. We first prepared the regional plan for MMR for the next 20 years. Considering all ongoing developments including the MTHL and Metro, we have identified seven potential growth centres that will emerge in and around the MTHL. The potential for future multimodal corridors was also factored into the plan.

The MMR region defies population demographics existing in India and enjoys a 90:10 urban: rural ratio. It is the most urbanised agglomeration in India with a 122 million population which is still very good with its own plus points. Currently 200 families migrate to Mumbai every day.

The Metro project timelines and public dedication.

SVRS: Our Metro master plan envisages a 337 kms network spread with 80 per cent completion over the next 2.5 to 3 years. Of these, eight lines are under active construction spanning 150 kms including underground and elevated corridors. This involves a lot of effort in terms of rehabilitation and resettlement of PAPs despite maintaining timelines. The first aspect is right of way (ROW). Secondly, environmental clearances and permissions are needed as the metro passes through sensitive ecosystems. Even if we do not encounter sensitive corridors, we still need clearances. Thirdly is the issue of land acquisition. Only after these three are taken care can project attention be shifted to technical challenges which are crucial but only after the three priority areas are sorted. This is where our focus lies.

The ROW issue is specific. Thus far, the delay of the Metro depots over various reasons was the challenge. Now, the depot for line 3 is finalized and after some amount of delay we achieved closure on the two depots concerning five lines. For line 4 the depot is finalised in Thane district's Mogharpada while for line 5 we have finalised Kasheli. We have already floated bids for both depots. Now, three lines will be commissioned and dedicated to the public even as their depots are simultaneously completed. Other works are ongoing parallelly.

We changed the line 4 contractor as it was not progressing. We have appointed another subcontractor and work has picked up on this line too, being the longest one, extending from Wadala to Thane and beyond. Including 4A, it is about



35 kms. The previous contractor was underperforming in terms of mobilising technical manpower and physical resources. After I joined up, I set some time limits and when this did not happen we made a decision. Decisions must be taken when they are relevant. The same decision may not be useful, say, one-and-a-half-years later and serve no purpose. The delay would have happened by then. Delays lead to more delays and in turn, further delays. With these two depots finalized three to four lakh commuters are assured. Mogharpada will service the 4 and 4A lines while line five will be looked after by the Kasheli depot. Line 10 will also be serviced by these two depots. A substantial number of four metro lines will be catered to by just these two depots. That's why I mentioned the importance of ROW way earlier.

For ensuring timelines on work decision making and constant monitoring is essential. I introduced a system of weekly reports. As you rightly said, work on the Metro is ongoing 24/7. Even at midnight or 3 am you can observe the ongoing work at Metro sites. I get weekly outcome based reports reaching me directly from the field and in case of shortfalls, I am right on top of it, be it construction or R&R issues, depot related or manpower and material challenges.

This issue had also cropped up during the work on line 2A and phase one of line 7 which were commissioned and people worked hard, 24/7, till public dedication in April 2022. We are now targeting phase two of two lines to be commissioned by January 2023 as a new year's gift. This will ensure the western suburbs are covered and for the first time an entire Metro network will be fully functional. Lines 2A and 7 will connect to line 1 at two different points at DN Nagar on line 2A and the other at Andheri for line 7. Goregaon metro will connect to the Oshiwara suburban station.

DCM Devendra Fadnavis' vision was for a seamless public commute across multiple public transport corridors using one smart ticket.

SVRS: Our target is seamless travel across public transport corridors even beyond Metro. Only today I held a meeting on this. An integrated network is the most important feature of our plan. We have written to the Railways for seamless connectivity for Metro passengers on the suburban rail systems and are also looking to make it BEST compatible.

There used to be a GOI issued smart card called the Mor card which invited parodies in a film that termed it as the No More card. Today, GOI has introduced the National Common Mobility Card (NCMC). While every public utility wants its own distinct card, Metro lines will be compatible with other modes and we are also considering inclusion of Intermediate public transport (IPT) providers like autorickshaws, taxis and also Uber and Ola to afford a comfortable and convenient passenger experience. Our card, which will be driven through handphone applications, will be ready in the next two months.

